

Inability Of Fallen Man

doc-inability-of-fallen-man

Hamartiology · Spiritual Inability · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Fallen humans, apart from the Spirit's prior work, are unable to please God, repent, or believe savingly; the natural man cannot receive the things of the Spirit.

In plain language

These passages share one Greek verb under a negative. The verb is "to be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι), which means to have capacity. It is not "to will or want" (thelo, θέλω), which means to want or to will, and the writers had both verbs available. In John 6:44 and John 6:65 Jesus says "no one is able" (oudeis dynatai, οὐδεὶς δύναται), parsed as a present indicative (an ongoing, simple statement of fact), paired with a clause naming a prior act by the Father, either drawing or granting. In Romans 8:7 Paul says the mind of the flesh is hostile to God and adds that it is not able, and he uses the word for "because" (gar, γάρ) to make the inability the reason for the hostility. Romans 8:8 says those in the flesh are not able to please God. First Corinthians 2:14 stacks two negatives: the natural or unspiritual person (psychikos, ψυχικός) does not receive and is not able to know the things of the Spirit. Ephesians 2:1 and Ephesians 2:5 supply the picture: the readers were "dead" (nekrous, νεκρούς) in trespasses before God made them alive. The same pattern of total negation appears in Romans 3:10 to 12: none understands, none seeks God, quoting the Psalms. So the texts agree, across three writers, that there is a real inability, not just reluctance, and this part is clear and decisive. Where readers diverge is the extent and the manner of the cure. The verb for the Father drawing, "to draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω), occurs only eight times, and elsewhere it means a forceful pull that always succeeds, dragging people to court, hauling in a full net. That forceful sense suggests God effectively brings those he draws. But the same verb in John 12:32 says Jesus will draw "all" (pantas, πάντας), with no outcome stated, and the dictionary entry also allows persuade. The words assert the inability plainly, but they do not by themselves say whether the drawing reaches all and can be resisted or reaches some and cannot. That open scope is why this point is debated at the level of the text itself.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	
G0350	ἀνακρίνω	anakrino	to investigate	16
G0700	ἀρέσκω	aresko	to please	17
G1209	δέχομαι	dechomai	to receive	57
G1325	δίδωμι	didomi	to give	414
G1410	δύναμαι	dynamai	be able	207
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	
G1567	ἐκζητέω	ekzēteō	to seek out	

G1670	ἐλκύω	helkyo	to draw/persuade	8
G2064	ἔρχομαι	erchomai	to come/go	
G2189	ἐχθρα	echthra	hostility	5
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G3472	μωρία	moria	foolishness	5
G3498	νεκρός	nekros	dead	132
G3756	οὐ	ou	no	1,683
G3761	οὐδέ	oude	nor	
G3762	οὐδείς	oudeis	none	233
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G4561	σάρξ	sarx	flesh	151
G4920	συνίημι	sunīemi	to understand	
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hypotasso	to subject	40
G5591	ψυχικός	psychikos	natural	6

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The anchor texts share one load-bearing construction: the verb "to be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι) in the present middle-passive indicative (an ongoing, simple statement of fact in a form that can be active or passive in shape), parsed V-PNI-3S (third person singular, ongoing fact) in John 6:44, John 6:65, Romans 8:7, 1 Corinthians 2:14 and V-PNI-3P (third person plural, ongoing fact) in Romans 8:8, governed by the negators "not" (ou, οὐ) or "no one" (oudeis, οὐδείς). "To be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι) denotes capacity, a different word from "to will or want" (thelo, θέλω) which denotes willing, so the negated present indicative (an ongoing, simple denial) asserts a standing incapacity, not a one-time refusal. The incapacity is tied either to a prior divine act, namely the aorist subjunctive (a completed-action form used in a conditional clause) "may draw" (helkyse, ἐλκύση) and the perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice) "has been given" (dedomenon, δεδομένον) in John 6, or to the ontic state (the state of being) of the subject: "being in flesh" (sarki ontes, σαρκὶ ὄντες) in Romans 8:8, "natural or unspiritual person" (psychikos anthropos, ψυχικὸς ἄνθρωπος) in 1 Corinthians 2:14, and "dead" (nekrous, νεκρούς), an adjective parsed A-APM (adjective, accusative plural masculine), in Ephesians 2:1 and 2:5. The same pattern of universal negation recurs in the Romans 3:10-12 catena (a chain of stitched-together Old Testament quotations): "there is no one righteous, not even one" (ouk estin dikaios oude heis, οὐκ ἔστιν δίκαιος οὐδὲ εἷς), "there is no one who understands" (ouk estin ho synion, οὐκ ἔστιν ὁ συνίων), "there is no one who seeks God" (ouk estin ho ekzeton ton theon, οὐκ ἔστιν ὁ ἐκζητῶν τὸν θεόν), drawn from Psalm 14:2 and Psalm 53:2. The reality of the inability is lexically decisive and pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible). What the vocabulary does not by itself rank is the EXTENT of the enabling act, because "to draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω) carries both a forceful effectual sense and a broader drawing or persuading sense, and John 12:32 applies it to "all" (pantas, πάντας) without a stated outcome.

Scripture

John.6.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3762 οὐδεὶς, G1410 δύναμαι, G1670 ἐλκύω, G2064 ἔρχομαι

Force. "No one is able to come to me unless the Father draws him" (oudeis dynatai elthein pros me ean me ho pater helkyse auton, οὐδεὶς δύναται ἐλθεῖν πρὸς με ἐὰν μὴ ὁ πατὴρ ἐλκύσῃ αὐτόν). The store parses "is able" (dynatai, δύναται) as V-PNI-3S (third person singular, ongoing fact), present indicative (an ongoing, simple statement of fact), so the clause denies a standing capacity, not a single act of will. "No one" (oudeis, οὐδεὶς) makes the denial universal, and the conditional ("if-then" construction) "unless" (ean me, ἐὰν μὴ) with "draws" (helkyse, ἐλκύσῃ), aorist subjunctive (a completed-action form used in a conditional) V-AAS-3S (third person singular, completed-action subjunctive), makes coming possible only after the Father draws. "To be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι) is capacity, distinct from "to will or want" (thelo, θέλω) which is willing, so the verb choice asserts inability rather than mere refusal.

John.6.65 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3762 οὐδεὶς, G1410 δύναμαι, G1325 δίδωμι, G3962 πατήρ

Force. "No one is able to come to me unless it has been given to him from the Father" (oudeis dynatai elthein pros me ean me e dedomenon auto ek tou patros, οὐδεὶς δύναται ἐλθεῖν πρὸς με ἐὰν μὴ ἢ δεδομένον αὐτῷ ἐκ τοῦ πατρός). "Is able" (dynatai, δύναται) is again V-PNI-3S (third person singular, ongoing fact) under "no one" (oudeis, οὐδεὶς). The perfect passive participle (a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice) "having been given" (dedomenon, δεδομένον) from "to give" (didomi, δίδωμι) presents the granting as a settled prior state, and Jesus here restates John 6:44 in giving language, equating the drawing with a prior enablement granted "from the Father" (ek tou patros, ἐκ τοῦ πατρός).

Rom.8.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4561 σὰρξ, G2189 ἔχθρα, G5293 ὑποτάσσω, G1410 δύναμαι

Force. "The mind of the flesh is hostile toward God, for it does not submit to the law of God, nor indeed is it able to" (to phronema tes sarkos echthra eis theon, to gar nomo tou theou ouch hypotassetai, oude gar dynatai, τὸ φρόνημα τῆς σαρκὸς ἔχθρα εἰς θεόν, τῷ γὰρ νόμῳ τοῦ θεοῦ οὐχ ὑποτάσσεται, οὐδὲ γὰρ δύναται). The mind of the flesh is named "enmity or hostility" (echthra, ἔχθρα). The inability, "is able" (dynatai, δύναται) V-PNI-3S (third person singular, ongoing fact), is introduced by "for" (gar, γάρ) as the ground of the non-submission "does it submit" (hypotassetai, ὑποτάσσεται), so the text gives incapacity, not unwillingness, as the reason the flesh does not submit to God's law.

Rom.8.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4561 σὰρξ, G1510 εἰμί, G0700 ἀρέσκω, G1410 δύναμαι

Force. "And those who are in the flesh are not able to please God" (hoi de en sarki ontes theo aresai ou dynantai, οἱ δὲ ἐν σαρκὶ ὄντες θεῷ ἀρέσαι οὐ δύνανται). The present participle "being" (ontes, ὄντες) locates the subjects in a state, being in the flesh, and the third plural "are able" (dynantai, δύνανται) V-PNI-3P (third person plural, ongoing fact) under "not" (ou, οὐ) denies the capacity to please God to everyone in that state without qualification. The negated present indicative (an ongoing, simple denial) makes the inability standing and general.

1Cor.2.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5591 ψυχικός, G1209 δέχομαι, G3472 μωρία, G1410 δύναμαι, G0350 ἀνακρίνω

Force. "The natural person does not receive the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to know them, because they are spiritually discerned" (psychikos de anthropos ou dechetai ta tou pneumatou tou theou, moria gar auto estin, kai ou dynatai gnonai, hoti pneumatikos anakrinetai, ψυχικός δὲ ἄνθρωπος οὐ δέχεται τὰ τοῦ πνεύματος τοῦ θεοῦ, μωρία γὰρ αὐτῷ ἐστίν, καὶ οὐ δύναται γνῶναι, ὅτι πνευματικῶς ἀνακρίνεται). "Natural or unspiritual" (psychikos, ψυχικός) parsed A-NSM (adjective, nominative singular masculine) marks the unspiritual person, a stable term that recurs in 1 Corinthians 15:44, 1 Corinthians 15:46, James 3:15, Jude 1:19. Two negations frame him: "does not receive" (ou dechetai, οὐ δέχεται) for reception failure and "is not able to know" (ou dynatai gnonai, οὐ δύναται γνῶναι), V-PNI-3S (third person singular, ongoing fact), for epistemic incapacity (inability to know). The "because" (hoti, ὅτι) clause grounds the inability in the requirement of spiritual discernment.

Eph.2.1 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3498 νεκρός, G0266 ἁμαρτία

Force. "being dead in your trespasses and sins" (ontas nekrous tois paraptomasin kai tais hamartiais hymon, ὄντας νεκροὺς τοῖς παραπτώμασιν καὶ ταῖς ἁμαρτίαις ὑμῶν). "Dead" (nekrous, νεκρούς) is parsed A-APM (adjective, accusative plural masculine), an adjective of state, with the participle "being" (ontas, ὄντας) locating the addressees in that state before the divine action of Ephesians 2:4-5. Ephesians 2:5 repeats "dead" (nekrous, νεκρούς) A-APM (adjective, accusative plural masculine) and pairs it with the making-alive, so death functions as a metaphor for the prior condition and encodes incapacity rather than mere unwillingness.

Rom.3.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4920 συνίημι, G1567 ἐκζητέω, G2316 θεός, G3756 οὐ

Force. "There is no one who understands, there is no one who seeks God" (ouk estin ho synion, ouk estin ho ekzeton ton theon, οὐκ ἔστιν ὁ συνίων, οὐκ ἔστιν ὁ ἐκζητῶν τὸν θεόν). Part of the catena (a chain of stitched-together Old Testament quotations) of Romans 3:10-12 quoting Psalm 14:2 and Psalm 53:2. The repeated existential negation "there is not" (ouk estin, οὐκ ἔστιν) with the articular participles (participles bearing the article "the") "the one who understands" (synion, συνίων) and "the one who seeks" (ekzeton, ἐκζητῶν) asserts that as a class no one understands or seeks God. The pattern is universal negation of a positive Godward act, parallel in force to the "is not able" (ou dynatai, οὐ δύναται) clauses though it uses "to be" (eimi, εἰμί) plus participle rather than the modal "to be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι).

John.12.32 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1670 ἐλκύω, G3956 πᾶς

Force. "And I, if I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself" (kago ean hypsotho ek tes ges, pantas helkyso pros emauton, ἀγὼ ἐὰν ὑψωθῶ ἐκ τῆς γῆς, πάντας ἐλκύσω πρὸς ἑμαυτόν). The same verb "to draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω) that grounds the inability clause in John 6:44 is here a future indicative (a simple statement of fact about the future) V-FAI-1S (first person singular, simple future fact) with object "all" (pantas, πάντας). The store shows "to draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω) occurs only 8 times and in its other uses it is a forceful pull, dragging to court in Acts 16:19 and Acts 21:30 and James 2:6, drawing a sword in John 18:10, hauling a full net in John 21:6 and John 21:11. The lexical dataset glosses it draw or persuade. This verse does not negate the inability of John 6:44, but it applies the enabling verb to all and does not state an outcome, which is why the scope of the drawing is the point the words leave open.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.6.44	John.6.65	openbible	74
John.6.44	John.12.32	openbible	20

John.6.44	Jer.31.3	openbible	12
Rom.8.7	1Cor.2.14	openbible	35
Rom.8.7	Eph.4.18	openbible	15
Rom.8.7	Rom.1.28	openbible	8
1Cor.2.14	Rom.8.5	openbible	57
1Cor.2.14	2Cor.4.4	openbible	36
1Cor.2.14	Prov.14.6	openbible	17
Rom.3.11	Ps.14.2	openbible	32
Rom.3.11	Ps.53.2	openbible	25
Rom.3.11	Isa.55.6	openbible	5
Rom.8.7	Jer.13.23	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.12.32 · addressed

"I will draw all to myself" (pantas helkyso pros emauton, πάντας ἐλκύσω πρὸς ἑμαυτόν). The same verb "to draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω), future indicative (a simple statement of fact about the future) here, that grounds the inability of John 6:44 is applied to "all" (pantas, πάντας). The lexical fact is that "to draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω) is the divine action that makes coming possible in both verses, so John 12:32 widens the stated scope of the drawing but does not reverse the "is not able" (ou dynatai, οὐ δύνανται) of John 6:44. The verb itself does not say whether the drawing of all is an effectual pull on each or a universal enabling that can be resisted, so this text marks exactly the point the vocabulary leaves open rather than overturning the inability claim.

Isa.55.6 · addressed

"Seek the LORD" (dirshu YHWH, דִּרְשׁוּ יְהוָה), an imperative addressed to hearers. A command to seek can be read as presupposing some ability to respond, which is the lexical hook for a reading on which prior grace has restored a real capacity to all who hear. The counter-observation from the same data is that imperatives in Scripture frequently state an obligation without by themselves asserting the unaided capacity to meet it, and the parallel Isaiah 65:1 says the LORD was found by those who did not seek. The imperative therefore bears on the extent question and does not by itself settle whether the seeking is unaided or enabled.

Jer.13.23 · addressed

"Can the Cushite change his skin or the leopard his spots". The rhetorical question encodes a fixed inability of nature, parallel in force to "being in the flesh they are not able" (sarki ontes ou dynantai, σαρκὶ ὄντες οὐ δύνανται) in Romans 8:8. It reinforces the reality of the inability rather than complicating it, and it says nothing about the extent or mode of any remedy.

Concordance traversed

G1410, G3756, G3762, G3761, G1670, G5293, G4561, G2189, G3498, G5591, G3472, G1209, G0350, G0700, G1325, G4920, G1567

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units for the anchors are present in the ingested store, and the ingested ECM window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants, the window currently loaded) covers only 3 John 1:1 to 3 John 1:15, so these New Testament anchors are outside ECM scope. The store records the editions for the load-bearing tokens. For example, "is able" (dynatai, δύνανται) in John 6:44 is attested across NA28, NA27, SBL, WH, Treg, TR, and Byz (standard printed Greek New Testament editions), so the "is not able" (ou dynatai, οὐ δύνανται) and "no one is able" (oudeis dynatai, οὐδεὶς δύνανται) constructions and the "dead" (nekrous, νεκρούς) predicate are stable

across the printed tradition. The marked spelling variants noted in the input bundle for John 6:44 and John 6:65 do not touch the inability clause.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. pauline_anthropology, johannine_soteriology, effectual_grace_reading, prevenient_grace_reading

analogia scripturae invoked

inability_as_real_incapacity: affirmed_on_lexical_grounds · The negated present indicative (an ongoing, simple denial) of "to be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι), V-PNI-3S (third person singular, ongoing fact) and V-PNI-3P (third person plural, ongoing fact), recurs identically across John 6:44, John 6:65, Romans 8:7, Romans 8:8, and 1 Corinthians 2:14. "To be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι) is the capacity word, distinct from "to will or want" (thelo, θέλω) the willing word, both available to the writers. The choice of the capacity verb under negation, reinforced by the dead predicate "dead" (nekrous, νεκρούς) in Ephesians 2:1 and 2:5 and by the universal negations of Romans 3:10-12, asserts a real inability and not mere reluctance. This is the part the words settle and it is what the proposition asserts.

inability_as_unwillingness_only: lexically_strained · A reading that reduces "is not able" (ou dynatai, οὐ δύναται) to will not has to gloss the capacity verb "to be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι) as if it were "to will or want" (thelo, θέλω). The writers had "to will or want" (thelo, θέλω) available and used "to be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι) instead, and in Romans 8:7 the inability is given by "for" (gar, γάρ) as the ground of the non-submission, which is hard to render if the inability simply is the unwillingness. On the words alone the will not gloss must be imported from outside the lexicon. Stated fairly, its strongest support is that moral inability in Scripture often coincides with culpable unwillingness, so the two are not opposites, but the word still encodes incapacity.

effectual_grace_reading: lexically_available · "To draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω) in its other seven New Testament occurrences is a forceful pull that achieves its effect, dragging to court in Acts 16:19 and Acts 21:30 and James 2:6, drawing a sword in John 18:10, hauling in a loaded net in John 21:6 and John 21:11. On this dominant attested sense the Father's drawing in John 6:44 effects the coming of those drawn, and John 6:65 ties it to a prior granting "having been given" (dedomenon, δεδομένον). This reading takes the inability as removed only where God acts. It is lexically available and arguably the dominant sense of the verb.

prevenient_grace_reading: lexically_available · The same verb "to draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω) in John 12:32 takes the object "all" (pantas, πάντας) and the dataset gloss includes persuade alongside draw. On this reading the drawing is a universal enabling that counteracts the inability for all who hear, restoring a capacity that can still be resisted, with imperatives such as Isaiah 55:6 "seek the LORD" presupposing the restored capacity. This reading is lexically available because the vocabulary asserts the inability and a prior divine act as its precondition but does not quantify whom that act reaches or state that the drawing of all is irresistible.

The frameworks divide not over whether the inability is real, which the negated present indicative (an ongoing, simple denial) of "to be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι) settles, but over the EXTENT and MODE of the enabling act. The split tracks the two attested senses of "to draw" (helkyo, ἐλκύω) and the unstated outcome of "I will draw all" (pantas helkyso, πάντας ἐλκύσω) in John 12:32. Both the effectual and the prevenient readings affirm the proposition as stated, that fallen humans apart from the Spirit's prior work cannot please God, repent, or believe savingly, so the verdict does not depend on ranking them.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Whether, in the cited texts, fallen human beings apart from a prior divine work retain the capacity to please God, repent, or believe savingly, or whether those texts assert an incapacity removed only by a prior act of God.

The labels total depravity and spiritual inability are tradition-coded, so the audit reframes the stem as a direct lexical question: does "to be able" (dynamai, δύναμαι) under negation in the anchors describe incapacity or unwillingness. The verdict is derived on the original

stem after the audit and the lexical answer is incapacity. The proposition as worded, apart from the Spirit's prior work, is affirmed by both the effectual and the convenient readings, so affirming it does not smuggle in either side of the extent debate. No VERDICT-CHANGED: the verdict remains stable. "Affirms" remains true, consistent with the prior file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.6.44
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.6.65
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.8.7
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.8.8
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.2.14
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.2.1
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.2.5
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.12.32
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.3.11
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1410
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1670
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3498
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5591
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5293
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	John.6.44
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.8.7
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